Structuring the Response

Four paragraphs: a reliable shape for any line graph.

The four-part shape

1. **Introduction:** one sentence that paraphrases the task.
2. **Overview:** one or two sentences on the main patterns, no data figures.
3. **Body paragraph 1:** one logical group, with figures.
4. **Body paragraph 2:** the rest, with figures.

In this course the overview comes second, so you never run out of time before you write it. IELTS also accepts it at the end.

Paraphrasing the task

- **Change the verb:** illustrates, compares, gives information about. Not proves or explains.
- **Change the structure:** *the number of visitors → how many people visited*
- **Change the time phrase:** *between 1995 and 2015 → over the twenty-year period from 1995 to 2015*. Not over the last twenty years or since.
- **Keep every detail:** what, who, where, when.
- Don't copy eight or more words in a row, and don't write the graph below.

What goes in the overview

- The overall direction of the lines
- Which line was highest or lowest, and whether that changed
- A crossover, or one line that changed much faster

Years as time references are fine: *after 2015*. Data figures belong in the body.

Grouping the body paragraphs

- **By category:** the line that stands apart, then the lines that behave alike
- **By time period:** first half, second half, if the pattern changes
- **By trend:** the lines that rose, the lines that fell

Keep each line in one place. Never one paragraph per year.

Useful phrases

Introduction	The line graph illustrates… · …over the period from X to Y
Overview	Overall, … · In general, … · It is clear that…
Body	In 2010, … · In contrast, … · Meanwhile, … · By the end of the period, …

Overview check

Overall, City A had 1.2 million visitors in 2020. Detail, not a pattern.

Overall, City A consistently attracted far more visitors than the other two, and all three saw long-term growth.